

Changing Elements of Organization's Culture

Chapter 7 — The Cultural Web

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Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to:

- **Define** organizational culture and its levels (Schein).
- **Analyze** culture using the "Cultural Web" framework.
- **Identify** the hard (formal) and soft (informal) elements of culture.
- **Evaluate** the role of subcultures in organizational change.
- **Apply** strategies to unfreeze and reshape cultural norms.

What is Organizational Culture?

Culture is the "social glue" that holds the organization together.

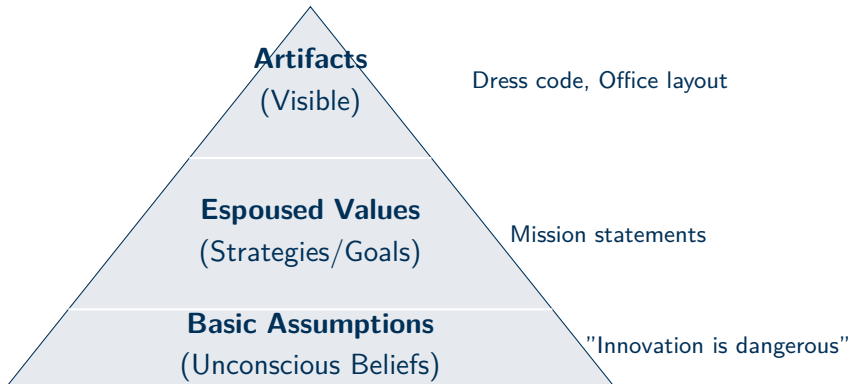
Definition

"The way we do things around here." It is the pattern of shared basic assumptions that the group learned as it solved its problems of external adaptation and internal integration.

Why is it hard to change? Because it is often invisible. It consists of unwritten rules and unconscious habits that have developed over years.

Schein's Three Levels of Culture

Culture exists at different depths. To change it, we must go deeper than the surface.



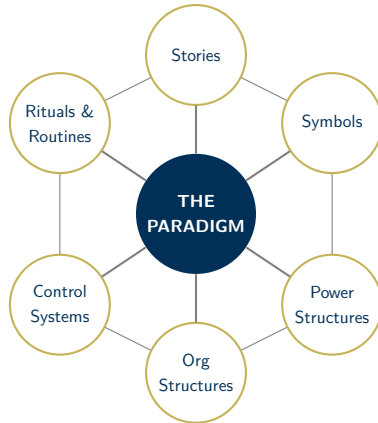
The Cultural Web (Johnson Scholes)

To change culture, we must map its component parts. The Cultural Web identifies the paradigm (core belief) and the six elements that reinforce it.

The Paradigm

The central set of assumptions or the "mental map" of the organization. It is surrounded by hard and soft elements.

Visualizing the Cultural Web



These are the informal, symbolic aspects of culture.

- **Stories:** The narratives told to new employees.
 - *Change Action:* Stop telling "glory days" stories; start telling stories of new successes.
- **Rituals Routines:** The daily habits (e.g., long meetings vs. stand-ups).
 - *Change Action:* Break old habits by changing the format of interactions.
- **Symbols:** Visual representations (e.g., corner offices, reserved parking).
 - *Change Action:* Remove status symbols to signal equality.

Changing Hard Elements

These are the formal mechanisms of culture.

- **Organizational Structure:** Hierarchies and reporting lines.
 - *Change Action:* Flattening the structure to encourage collaboration.
- **Control Systems:** What is measured and rewarded (KPIs, Bonuses).
 - *Change Action:* If you want teamwork, stop rewarding individual sales only.
- **Power Structures:** Who makes the decisions?
 - *Change Action:* Empowering lower levels (Distributed Leadership).

Subcultures: Silos and Tribes

Organizations rarely have one monolithic culture.

Subcultures

Distinct groups with their own norms, often based on function (e.g., "The Engineers" vs. "Sales") or geography.

The Change Challenge:

- Subcultures can become "Counter-Cultures" that actively resist the central change.
- Leaders must act as "bridge-builders" to integrate these silos.

A Process for Cultural Change

Changing culture is slow and requires persistence.

1. **Diagnose:** Use the Cultural Web to map the *current* culture.
2. **Define:** Map the *desired* culture needed to support the new strategy.
3. **Identify Gaps:** Where are the misalignments? (e.g., Strategy says "Innovation," but Control Systems punish failure).
4. **Intervene:** Change the visible artifacts first (easiest) to signal shift, then work on values.

The Role of Leadership in Cultural Change

Leaders are the "Architects" of culture.

Primary Embedding Mechanisms (Schein)

- What leaders pay attention to, measure, and control.
- How leaders react to critical incidents and crises.
- How leaders recruit, select, promote, and excommunicate.

"If you do not manage culture, it manages you."

Summary:

1. Culture is deep-seated (Iceberg) and reinforced by multiple elements (The Web).
2. You cannot change the "Paradigm" directly; you must change the elements surrounding it.
3. Coherence is key: **Stories, Systems, and Structure** must all tell the same new truth.
4. Leaders must model the new culture visibly and consistently.

Thank You

Questions?